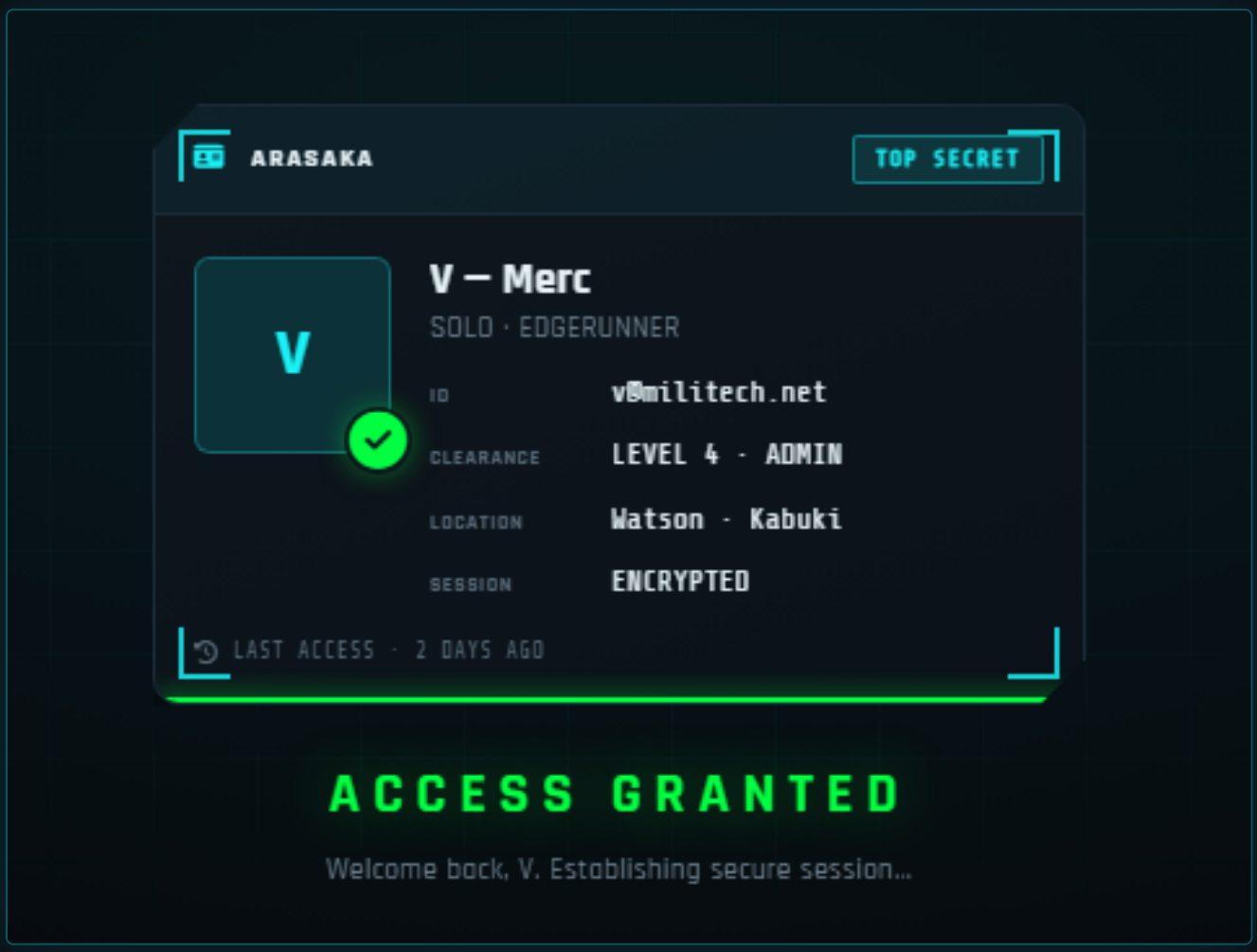
// A MODULE FOR FOUNDRY VTT + CYBERPUNK RED

NIGHT CITY MESSENGER

Getting Started Guide — for GMs and players



github.com/christinophrappuccino/night-city-messenger

// START HERE

What is this module?

Night City Messenger adds phones, computers, and hacking to your Cyberpunk RED game. Everything looks like the real thing, not like a menu.

- Every player character gets an **Agent** — an in-game phone with messages, contacts, and money transfers. Players can customize how theirs looks.
- Scenes have **networks**. Your phone only picks up networks that exist where you are. Some need a password or a skill check to join. Some areas have no signal at all.
- The GM can turn any Item into a **data shard** (an encrypted file players crack open) or a **terminal** (a computer players log into). Both can hold all kinds of content: spreadsheets, camera feeds, bank accounts, chat logs, and more.
- Players can make their own shards and programs with the **Shard Encoder**: forged documents, fake chat logs, keyloggers, and more.
- Players can steal data from machines, or plant fake data and malware on them. Risky actions use real Cyberpunk RED skill rolls. Failed rolls build up **heat** that the GM can punish.
- The GM controls everything from one **Admin Panel**.

> **PACING** Most tables add features in this order: **messages** → **contacts** → **networks** → **shards** → **terminals** → **hacking**. Each step works fine without the ones after it. You don't need to learn all of it at once.

> **WHO READS WHAT** **GMs:** read Part 1 to set up (about 15 minutes), come back to the rest when you want it. **Players:** Part 2 is all you need, plus Part 5 if your GM lets you make shards.

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// PART 01 · GM

GM setup

You need: Foundry VTT v12 and the Cyberpunk RED Core system. NCM uses the real CPR rules for skill checks, money, roles, and Black ICE.

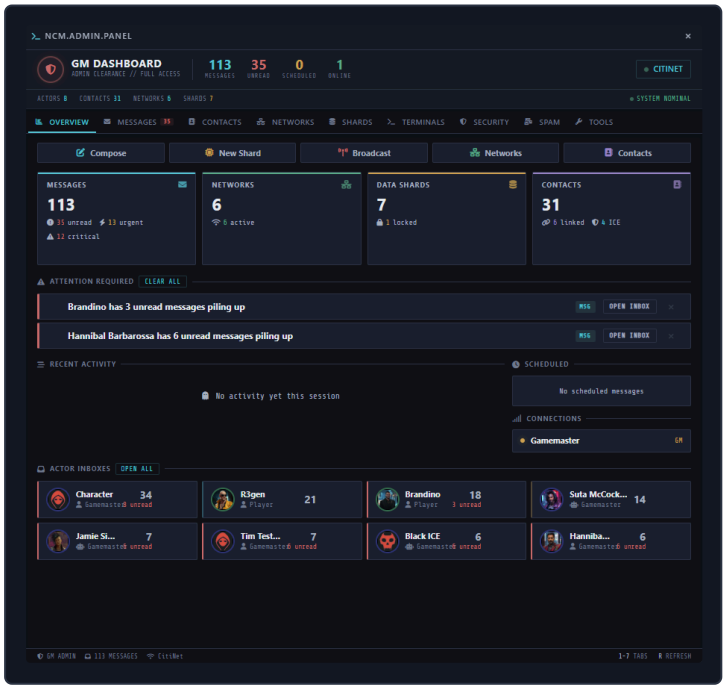
▸ 1 — FIND THE BUTTONS

After you enable the module, look for the **satellite dish** icon in the left toolbar. It has these buttons:

BUTTON	WHO SEES IT	WHAT IT DOES
Open Inbox	everyone	opens your phone
Compose Message	everyone	write a message
Contacts	everyone	your contact book
Network Management	GM only	set up networks
Admin Panel	GM only	the GM control center

▸ 2 — OPEN THE ADMIN PANEL

This is your control center. It has 9 tabs: **Overview, Messages, Contacts, Networks, Shards, Spam, Terminals, Security, Tools**. The Overview tab shows your players' characters and recent messages.



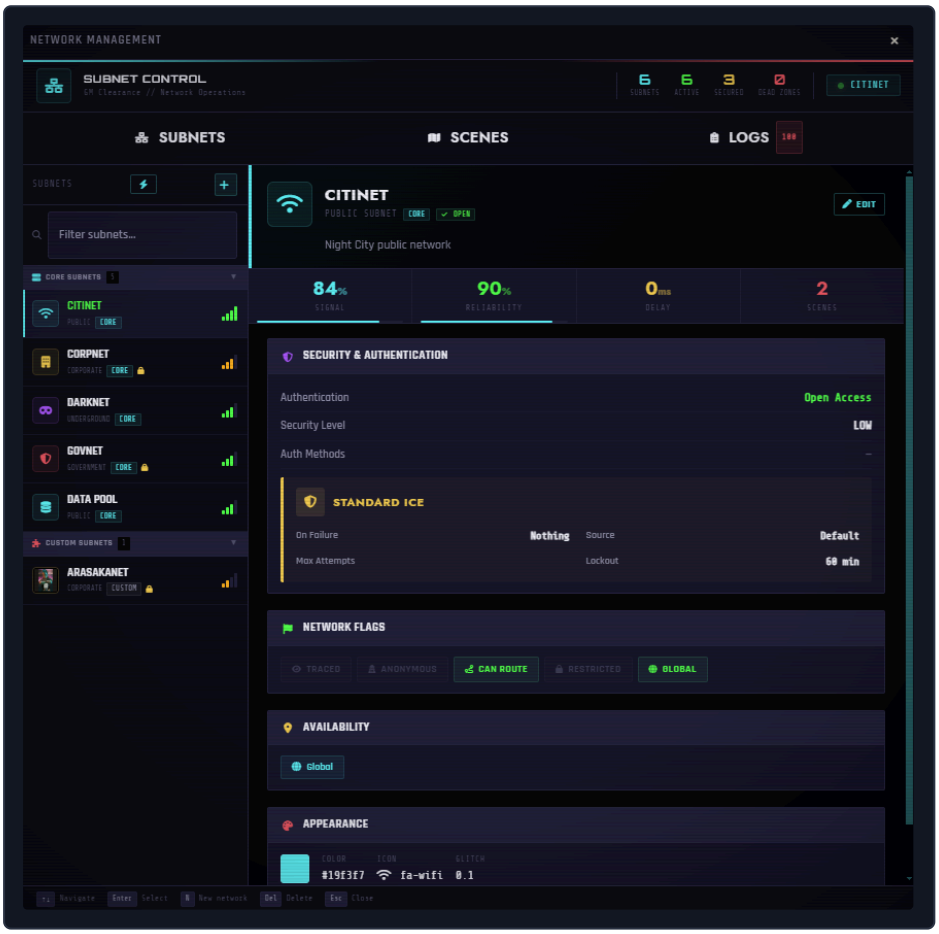
▪ The Admin Panel — Overview tab, with a few registered characters

▸ 3 — SET UP NETWORKS (5 MINUTES)

Open **Network Management**. The module comes with some networks already. Add your own for districts, corporations, or locations. Each network gets a name, a color, and (if you want) security: a password, a skill check, a key item, or a mix.

Then go to the **Scenes tab** and pick which networks work on which scenes. You can also mark a scene as a **dead zone** — no signal at all. Changes save automatically.

> **TIP** Skip the security stuff at first. Open networks are fine to start with.



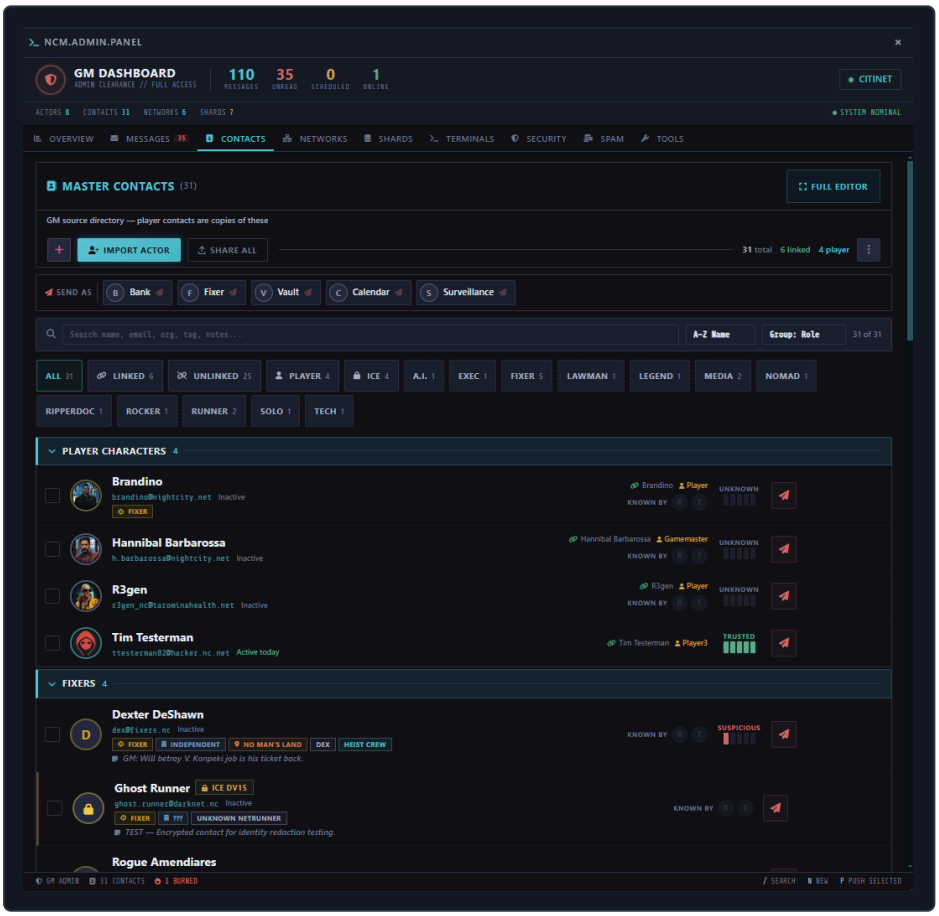
▪ Network Management — networks on the left, the selected network's setup on the right

4 — ADD SOME CONTACTS (5 MINUTES)

Go to Admin Panel → **Contacts**. This is your master list of every NPC that players can message. From here you can:

- **Import Actor** — turn an existing actor into a contact in two clicks. The portrait and email come with it.
- **Push contacts to players** — give an NPC's contact card to one player or the whole party.
- **Groups** — the Groups card at the top of the tab. Make a named list of contacts ("The Crew", "Arasaka Leads"), then **Push** it to a player and it lands in their contact book, contacts included. Re-pushing updates their copy.
- Mark an address as **send-only** — good for system addresses like `alerts@arasaka.com`. Players get mail from it but can't reply.

> **TIP** Don't build the whole city. Two or three NPCs your party actually talks to is plenty for the first night.



▪ Admin Panel → Contacts tab, with a few NPC contacts and the Import Actor button visible

5 — INSTALL THE MACROS

Admin Panel → **Tools** → **Import / Reinstall Macros**. This adds two macro folders with handy shortcuts for you and your players. Optional, but nice to have.

Addresses in bulk: Tools → **Email Domains & Addresses** also exports every character and master-contact address as CSV or JSON, and imports a `name, email` list — matched to a character by name, then a contact, else a new contact — with the whole plan shown before anything is written.

6 — PICK A CLOCK

In Module Settings, find **Time Provider**. This controls what clock the module uses for timestamps and countdowns. Your options: real time, world time (works with Simple Calendar), manual (you move it forward yourself), or a fake in-game date. Real time is fine to start. You can change it later.

7 — BRING IN THE PLAYERS

That's it. Tell your players to click **Open Inbox**. The module walks them through the rest.

MAKE THE GM TOOLS COMFORTABLE

Admin Panel → Tools → **Admin Appearance** sets the look and text size for every GM window (dark, light, or high contrast). The inbox, composer, and contacts windows have an **eye button** in their title bar that switches between your admin look and exactly what players see.

> **UPGRADING FROM V1.0** The module's id changed from `cyberpunkred-messenger` to `night-city-messenger`, so Foundry treats it as a new module. Back up your world, disable and uninstall the old one, install the new one, then load the world as GM and click **Yes** on the migration prompt. Players just log in once. Don't run both versions at the same time.

> **STARTING OVER** Admin Panel → Tools → Danger Zone → **Factory Reset** wipes every message, shard, and terminal in the world, and (unless you untick it) resets the module settings. You have to type RESET to confirm. Back up first.

// PART 02 · PLAYERS

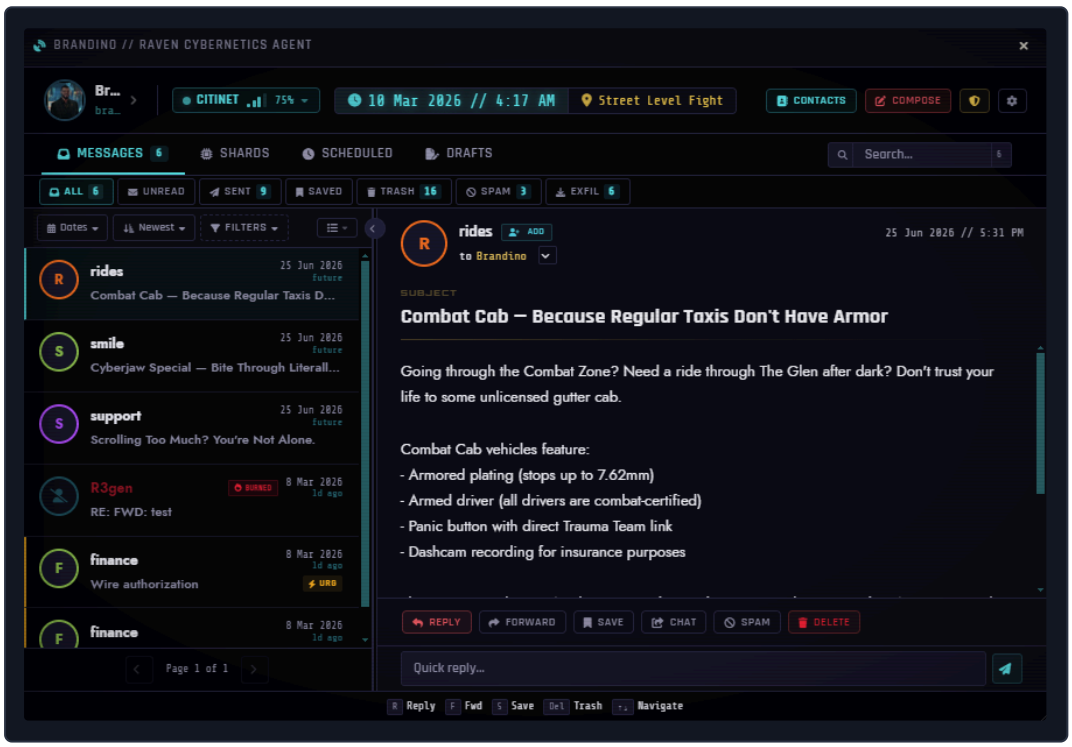
Players: your Agent

FIRST TIME

Click **Open Inbox** (the envelope icon under the satellite dish). The module will ask you to:

1. **Pick your character**, if you own more than one.
2. **Pick your email address** — a name plus a domain, like `v.wraith@nightcity.net`. It suggests names based on your character. The GM decides which domains exist.

Done. NPCs and other players can now message you at that address.



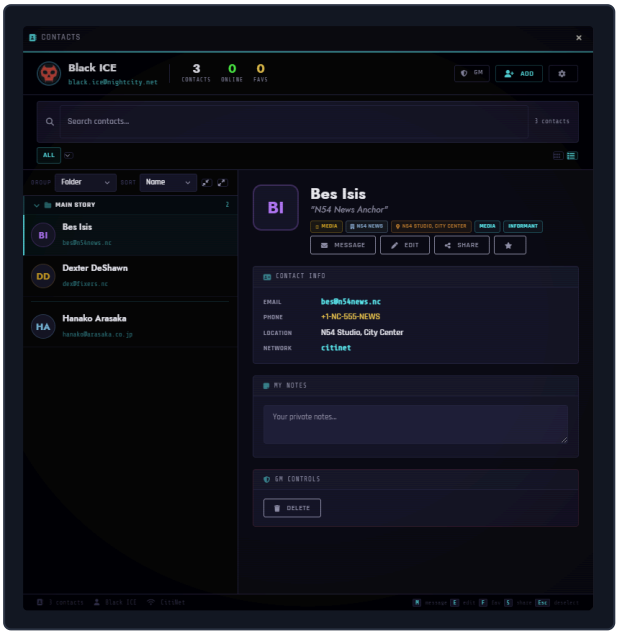
A player's inbox (Message Viewer) with a few messages and the network pill visible

USING YOUR INBOX

- **Folders** — Inbox, Sent, Saved, Trash, and Spam. There's a "Mark all read" button at the end of the filter row.
- **Networks** — at the top of the window. You only see networks that reach the scene you're on. A padlock means the network needs a password or a skill check. Some messages only open on certain networks.
- **Threads** — click the **Thread** button on a message to see the whole conversation in one view.
- **Money** — a message can have eddies attached. Click **Claim** and the money goes straight to your character sheet. It can only be claimed once.
- **Self-destructing messages** exist. If you get one, read it carefully. It won't be there later.

CONTACTS

The **Contacts** button opens your personal contact book. You can set trust levels, write notes, and mark favorites. When a stranger messages you, use **Add to Contacts** right from the message. Some contacts are protected by ICE and need a skill check to unlock.

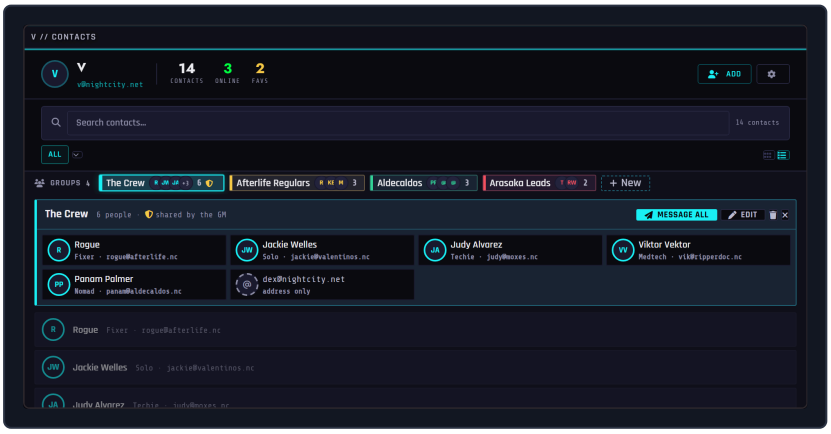


▪ Your contact book — trust levels, notes, and favorites

GROUPS

Groups sit in a row of chips under the search bar. A group is a named list of your contacts — make one with **New**, or the GM can hand you one (it shows a shield). Each chip shows a few member faces; click it to see everyone in it, message them all at once, or edit the list. Clicking a face opens that contact. The groups you message most stay at the front, and past six the rest fold behind **+N more**.

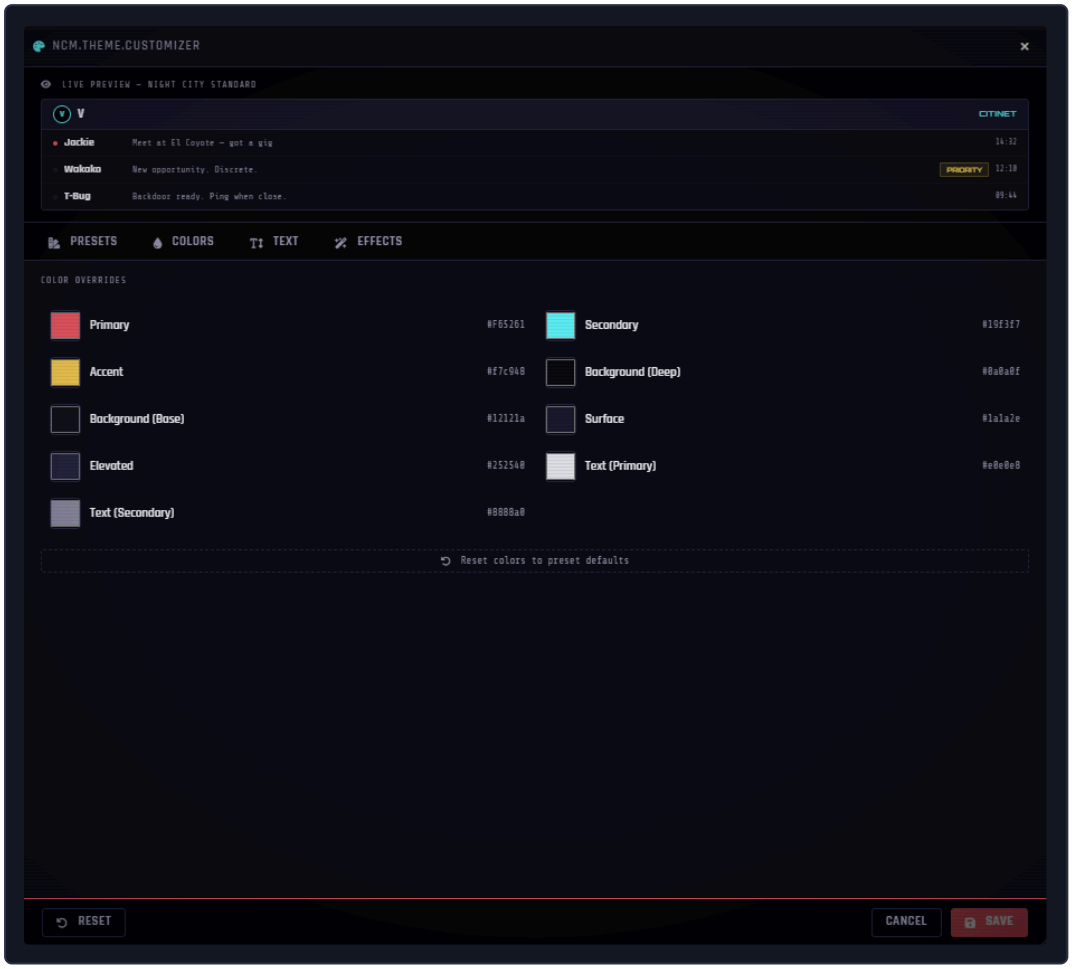
A message sent to several people shows a party chip next to the To line, and a **Reply All** button beside Reply.



▪ Groups as chips; the open one shows its members in a tray below.

MAKE IT YOURS

Open the **Theme Customizer** from your inbox. You can change colors, fonts, text size, wallpaper, and effects, and give your Agent a custom name. Only you see your theme.



- The Theme Customizer — colors, fonts, wallpaper, effects, and your Agent's name

IF YOU OWN MORE THAN ONE CHARACTER

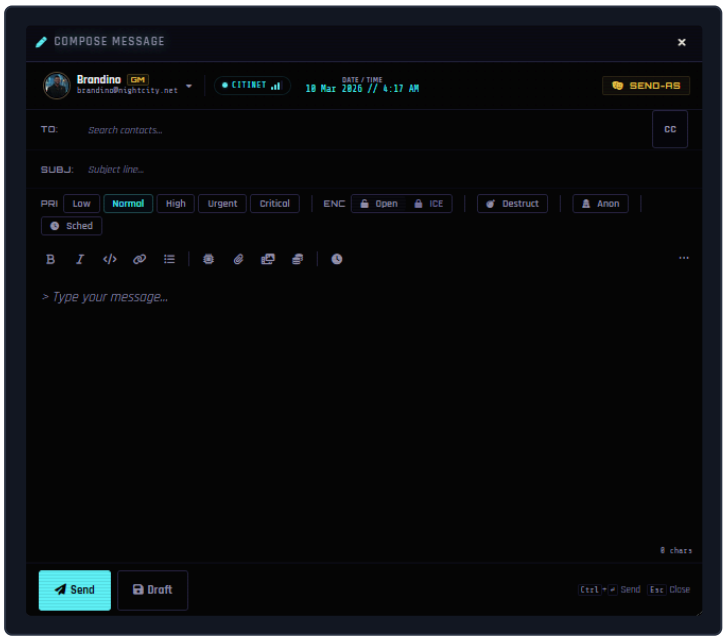
> **IMPORTANT** Terminals and shards act as your **operator** — the character who rolls the dice, pays, and gets paid. If you own several characters, an **OPERATOR chip** shows up on terminal screens. **Check it before you roll.** If the wrong character is picked, the wrong character gets the money.

// PART 03 · GM

Sending mail

Once messaging works, here's what you can do with it:

- **Send as anyone.** Put any contact in the From field. When players message an NPC, you get a popup, and the mail collects in the **NPC Inbox** panel (Admin → Messages) where you can reply.
- **Anonymous send.** Turn this on in settings, and the composer gets a checkbox that hides who you are. Players see a glitchy masked avatar instead. They can reply without knowing who they're talking to, and if you allow it, they can roll to trace you. Great for mystery employers.
- **Self-destruct.** Set a message to delete after it's read, or after 1, 6, or 24 hours.
- **Scheduled messages.** Write now, send later.
- **One message, many people.** Type a group's name in To and it goes to everyone in it; each recipient gets their own copy and can Reply All. **Mass Broadcast** (Admin → Messages) has a **Send to** picker for the whole party or one of your groups, and tells you by name if anyone couldn't receive it.
- **Share to chat.** Posts a message as a chat card. Anyone reading it who doesn't have the sender in their contacts gets an **Add contact** button right on the card.
- **Spam.** The Spam tab has ready-made junk mail you can send to players, and can even send it automatically when they join certain networks. It sounds silly, but a "spam" message can carry anything a real message can. Use that.



▪ The composer — attach eddies, set self-destruct, schedule, or send anonymously.

// PART 04 · GM

Data shards

A data shard is an Item that has been turned into an encrypted file. It's loot that players crack open.

▸ MAKE ONE

Right-click any Item and pick **Convert to Data Shard**. As GM, it converts right away. Right-click again and pick **Configure Shard** to set the difficulty, the skill needed, lockouts, and Black ICE that attacks players who fail.

Players can make shards too, with the Shard Encoder (see Part 05).

▸ PUT STUFF INSIDE

Open the shard and add entries. There are **18 kinds of content**, and each one looks like the real thing:

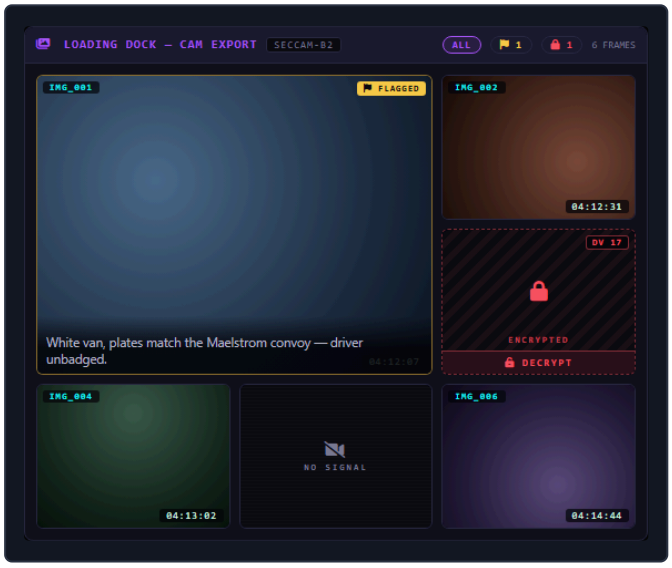
GROUP	TYPES
Messages & records	message, chat log, records database, calendar, note
Data & money	spreadsheet, bank account, password vault, eddies drop
Media & intel	photo gallery, live camera feed, document, dossier, audio/video log, building plan, location pin
Dangerous	program, malware, system log

> **FASTEST WAY TO LEARN** Every type has a **Load example** button. Load the example, look at it, change it.

Almost anything can be locked. Encrypted photos, blacked-out paragraphs, hidden identities — each one takes a skill roll to open, and you can set failed rolls to trigger a trace.



▪ A bank account entry — and the siphon minigame players use to drain it.



▪ A photo gallery: flagged evidence, timestamps, and an encrypted frame that takes a roll to decrypt.

GIVE IT TO THE PLAYERS

The shard is a normal Item. Hand it over however you like: drop it as loot, put it on a body, trade it, or attach it to a message. The player cracks it open with a skill check. There's a whole animated hacking sequence, and lockouts if they keep failing. You never need to touch the shard's permissions — see the next page.

MAKE IT LOOK RIGHT

Configure Shard → **Theme** sets the shard's colors, fonts, wallpaper, text size, and contrast, starting from a preset (corporate dossier, black market, medical record, and more). Save a look you like and reuse it on other shards. You can also save a **full shard setup** to the library; its security settings only come along if you tick the box when saving.

ATTACHING ONE TO A MESSAGE

In the composer, the microchip button beside the paperclip is **Attach Data Shard**; it lists every shard in the world and in any character's gear. The player opens it **straight from the message**: the shard appears as a DATA SHARD card under the body, and clicking it opens the shard viewer. It is also listed on the Agent's **Shards** tab as *Received*.

A shard you attach to a message stays a **world item that players have no permission on**, and that is how it should be: any permission at all would put the shard in their Items sidebar before you meant them to see it. When a player breaks into it, the module asks the GM's client to record the unlock, so nothing about the shard has to change hands first.

> **GM ONLINE** This works the same way as every other player action on a shard or terminal: a GM needs to be connected. If no GM is online, the player is told and nothing is lost.

If you really do want to hand a shard over outright — give the player the Item, not just access to it — the **Permissions** button on the shard's row in Admin → Shards opens Foundry's ownership dialog. It only shows for world items; a shard on a character's sheet already follows that character.

LETTING PLAYERS WRITE ON THEM

Players can encode their own shards once **Player Authoring** is switched on (Admin → Shards). Shards that already exist follow a simple rule:

SHARD	PLAYERS MAY…
One **you** made	read it, hack it, claim what's inside. Never add to it or rewrite it.
One a **player** encoded	only the character who encoded it can re-open it in the Encoder.

To change that for one shard, open Configure Shard → Security → **Player Editing**: **Locked**, **Maker only**, or **Anyone who qualifies** (anyone who passes your encoder gate). The Admin → Shards row shows an **Editable** badge on any shard you've opened up.

A re-encode adds files to the chip and re-rolls how convincing the whole thing is, at a small extra DV for having to agree with what's already on it. The lock stays exactly as it was, and a bad roll leaves the shard unchanged rather than wrecking it. The **Rewrite a sloppy shard** switch in Player Authoring turns re-encoding off for everyone.

> **READING IS NOT WRITING** The Player Editing rule only governs adding and rewriting. Hacking, cracking a password, decrypting a photo and claiming eddies are the shard being *used*, and are never blocked by it.

// PART 05 · EVERYONE

Players make shards

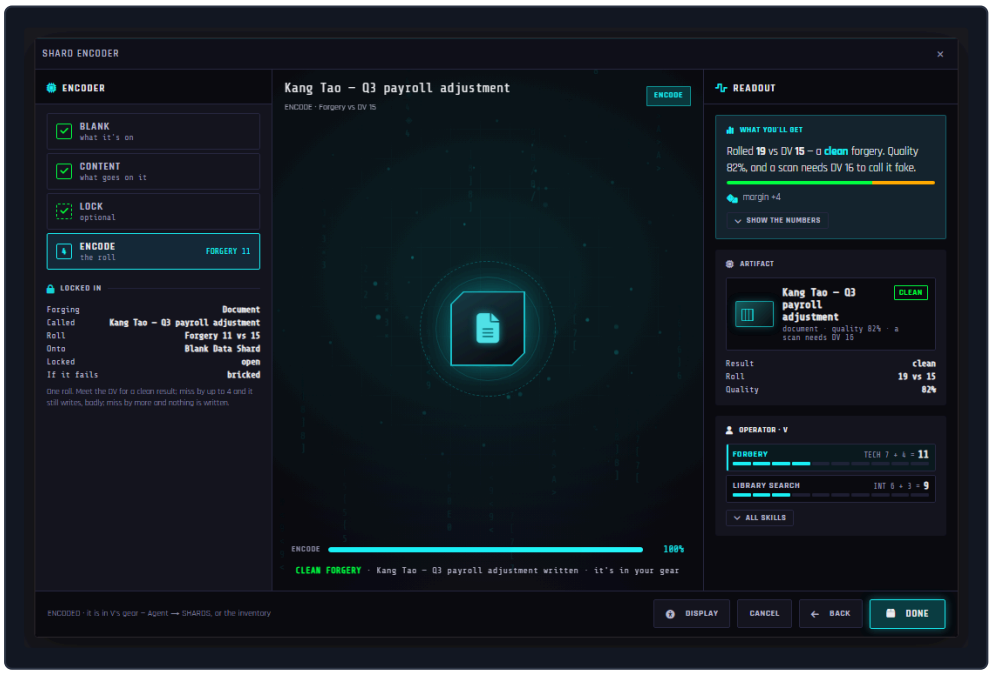
The Shard Encoder lets players make their own data shards and programs: a forged dossier, a fake chat log, a keylogger to plant on a corp terminal.

▸ OPEN IT

Three ways in: **Encode new** on the Shards tab of your Agent, **right-click an item** on your character sheet, or the empty slot in the **Program Deck**. If you don't see any of them, your GM hasn't allowed your character to make shards yet.

▸ FOUR STEPS

STEP	WHAT YOU DO
1 · Blank	Pick a chip you own, or buy a blank. Give it a name, a look, and the screen it shows when it starts up.
2 · Content or Program	Write files on it (documents, chat logs, photos, cred drops…) or build a program (scanner, keylogger, backdoor, Black ICE).
3 · Lock (optional)	Add a password, encryption, or a bite-back. How strong you can make it depends on your roll.
4 · Encode	One skill roll decides how it comes out.

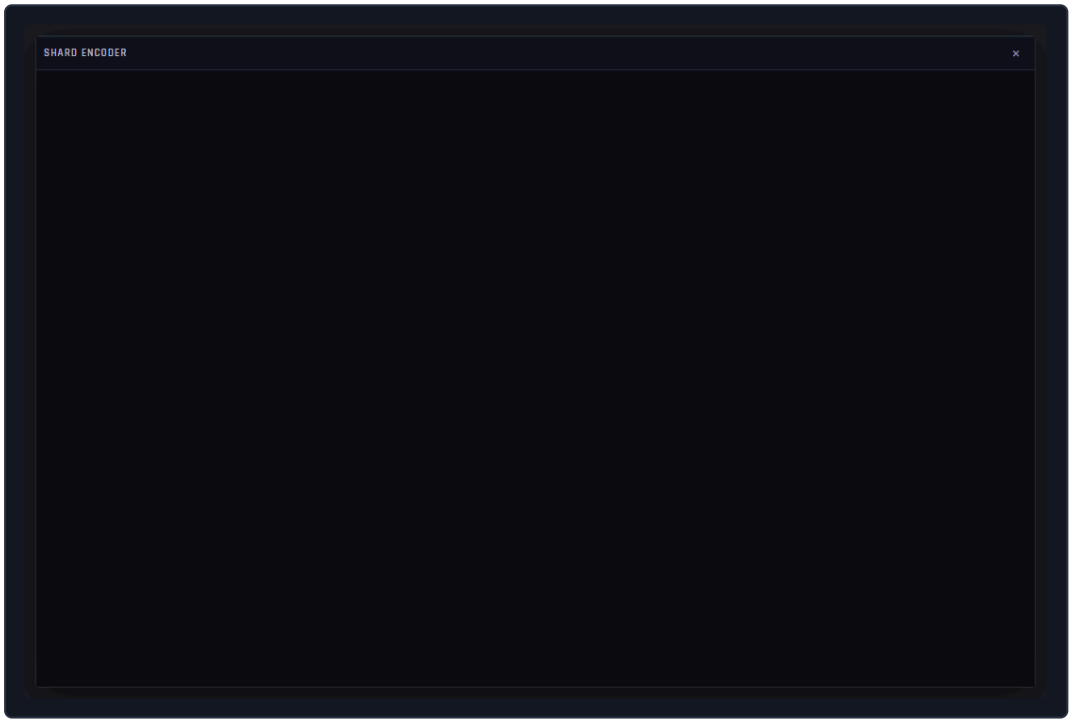


▪ A forged document encoded clean. The readout says what the roll got you, and how hard the fake is to spot.

HOW THE ROLL WORKS

- **Clean** — meet the DV. It works, and it's hard to tell it's fake.
- **Sloppy** — miss by a little. It still works, but someone who runs **ANALYZE** on it can catch the fake.
- **Rejected** — miss by a lot. Nothing is written. A cheap blank is ruined (bricked); a premium one only gets wiped.

Plain messages, notes, and cred drops aren't fakes, so they don't need a roll at all. Putting eddies on a shard moves them out of your wallet; it doesn't create money. More files on one chip make the roll harder.



▪ Building a keylogger. Your Interface rank decides which programs you can build; the roll decides how many charges it gets and how well it hides.

SELLING IT

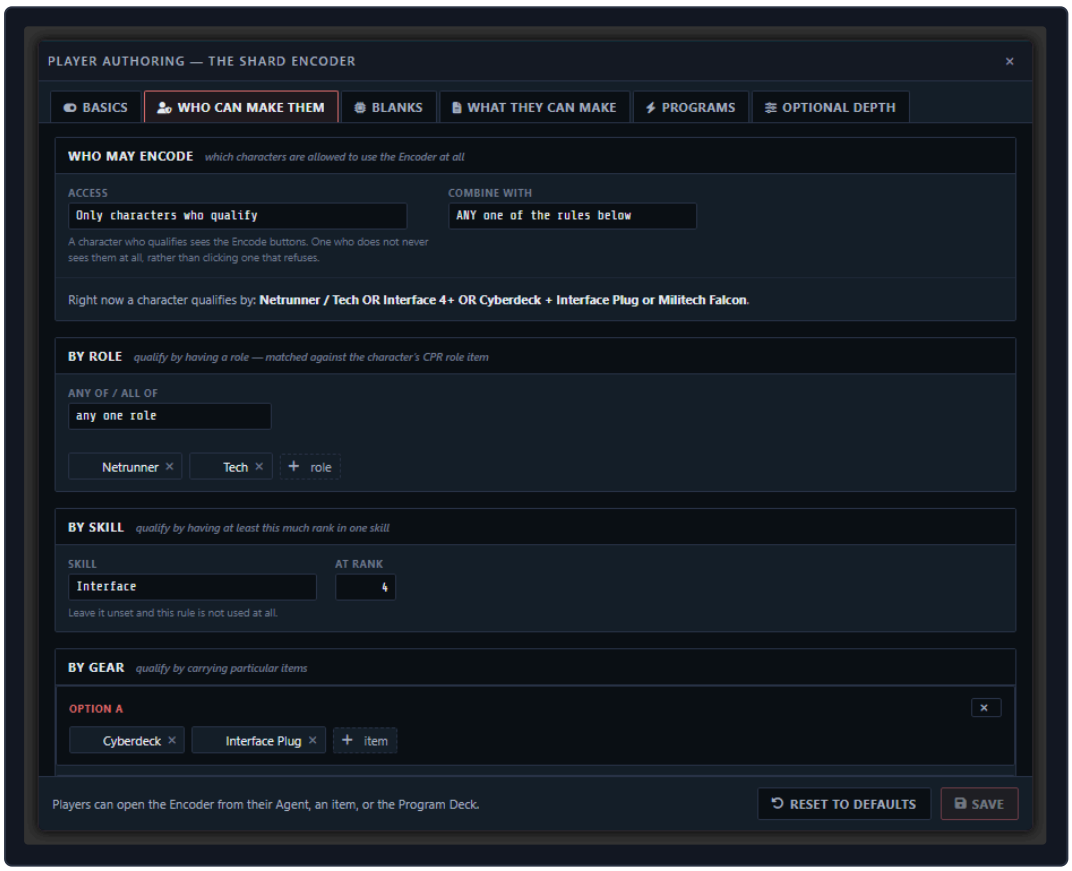
When the shard is done, you can name a price. Your GM approves, counters, or turns it down, and the price only goes on the item once it's approved.

> **HARD TO READ?** The **Display** button at the bottom of the Encoder changes text size, contrast, animation, and spacing for you alone, with presets like Large text and Calm.

FOR THE GM: PLAYER AUTHORING

Admin Panel → Shards → **Player Authoring** controls all of it. Turn it on first; it's off until you do.

- **Who can make them** – anyone, or only characters with a certain role, skill rank, gear, or by name. Characters who don't qualify never see the buttons.
- **Blanks** – price tiers (Scrap, Standard, Premium by default): what each costs, how many files it holds, and what a failed roll does to it.
- **What they can make** – which of the 18 content types are allowed, and the skill and DV for each.
- **Programs** – which programs can be built and what rank they need.
- **Optional depth** – off by default: bonuses for carrying gear like a cyberdeck, game time spent encoding, and a friend helping with the roll.



▪ Player Authoring: here, only a Netrunner or Tech, someone with Interface 4+, or someone carrying the right gear can make shards.

> **FINDING PLAYER SHARDS** A shard a player made lives on their character, so it isn't in your Items directory. Admin → Shards → **Copy Shards to Items** puts a live copy of each in a "Player-Made Shards" folder, sorted by character. Player-made shards also show a "Made by" badge in the Shards tab.

// PART 06 · GM

Terminals

A terminal is an Item turned into a computer that players log into. A corp workstation, a ripperdoc's records, a street bulletin board.

▸ MAKE ONE

Right-click an Item and pick **Convert to Terminal**. The setup screen has six tabs:

- **Identity** — name, organization, folder names.
- **Accounts** — the important one. Each account is a login with its own mailbox **and its own files**. Set a username, portrait, admin rights, and security (password, skill check, or key item). Accounts can be **hidden** — players only find them if they learn the username somewhere else.
- **Theme** — colors, fonts, and wallpaper for this machine. There's a **preset library** with 12 ready-made looks (Arasaka workstation, NCPD precinct, Trauma Team, street BBS, and more) that set everything up in one click.
- **Boot & Login** — the startup screen (or a video that plays instead), six different login screen styles, four **mailbox layouts** for after login (Classic, Tabs, TTY, Desktop), a message of the day, and a screensaver. Each terminal can have its own sound effects too.
- **Network** — which network the machine itself is connected to.
- **Exfil** — what players are allowed to do with what they find (see below).

▸ PUT THINGS ON IT

Everything a machine holds is in **Accounts**. Each account row folds open into its **mail** (the folders from Identity) and its **files** (its home folder). Above the accounts sits the **Shared volume** — files on the machine itself, which every login sees. **+ Message** and **+ File** open the same editor the shards use; **+ Folder** adds a folder, and every folder has a **who can open it** control: everyone, admins only, a clearance level, or named accounts. A player who can't open a folder sees it locked with the reason, never an empty space.

▸ PUT IT IN THE WORLD

Drag the terminal Item onto the map. It becomes a pin that players double-click to log in. You can require their token to be standing near it. Or skip the pin and let players open the Item directly.

WHAT PLAYERS SEE

Boot screen, then login, then the machine — all in that machine's own look. Under the account name a switch picks **MAIL** (the account's folders) or **FILES** (a directory tree of the account's home and the shared volume). Machines hold both mail and files (camera feeds, spreadsheets, logs). If an account belongs to an NPC, mail sent to that NPC also shows up on the machine. The paper trail is really there.



▪ Logging into an Arasaka workstation — the credential badge fills in, then the machine opens its mailbox.

TAKING DATA

The Exfil tab controls what players can do with files they find. Each action can be off, allowed, or allowed-with-a-roll:

Download · Burn to shard · Forward · Leak (posts it to public chat) **· Sell** (instant eddies) **· Wipe** (delete it — you can restore it from a recycle bin)

Failing a gated roll triggers a trace. One fun detail: live camera feeds can't be downloaded, but players can save a single frame, loop a camera, or cut it. A looped camera shows a frozen timestamp — which someone might notice.

// PART 07 · GM

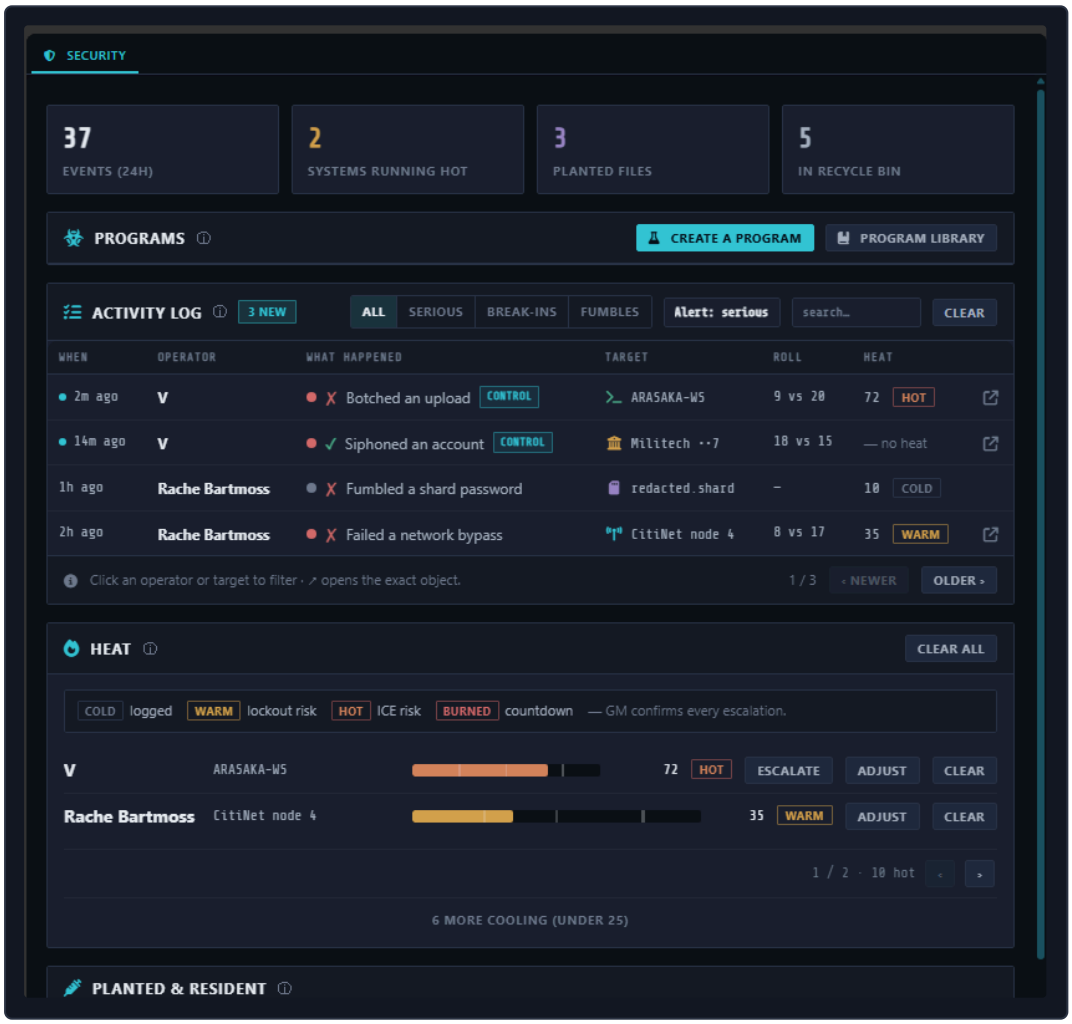
Hacking and consequences

This is the deep end. Skip it until your table wants it.

▸ TRACE & HEAT

Every risky roll reports to Admin → **Security**:

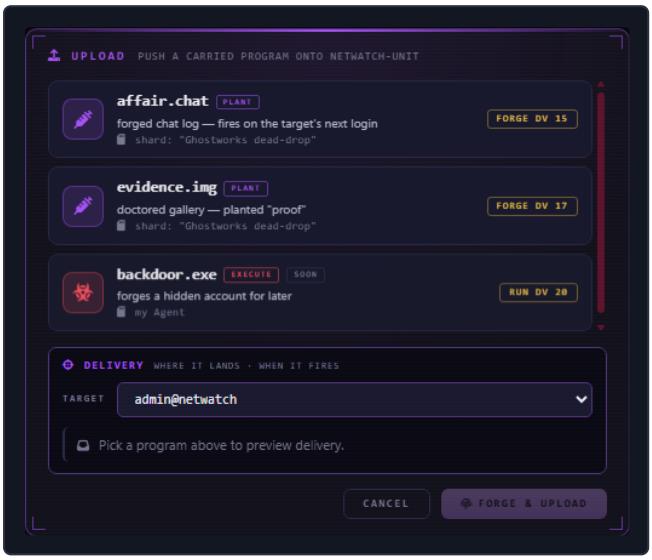
- **Activity Log** — a full record of who did what and whether it worked.
- **Heat** — failed rolls build heat on whoever failed them. Heat fades over time. When it gets high, you can hit back: lock them out, attack with Black ICE, or start a **countdown** the player watches tick down on their screen ("Arasaka is closing in").



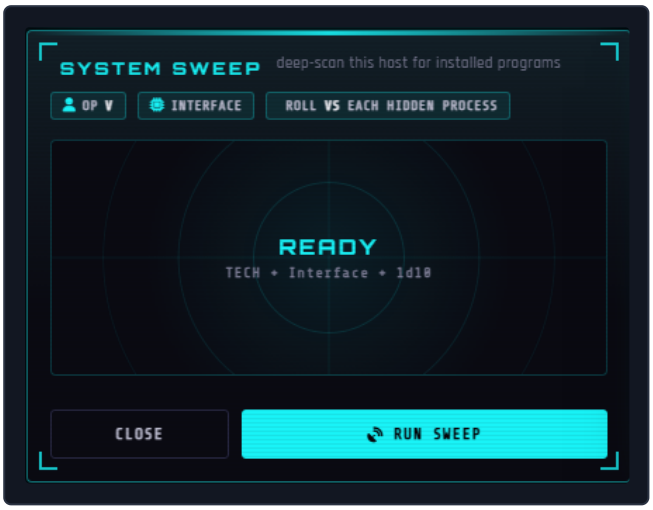
▪ Admin → Security: the activity log, per-operator heat bars, planted files, and the recycle bin — your whole consequence dashboard.

PLANTING FAKE DATA

Players can also put things ON a machine. They carry a forged file (a fake chat log, a doctored photo) to a terminal and upload it. A forge roll decides how it goes: **clean**, **sloppy** (it works, but an inspection will reveal it's fake), or **rejected**. Planted files go off the next time someone logs in. You choose in settings whether they fire on their own or wait for your go-ahead.



▪ Uploading a forged file from a carried shard onto a terminal.



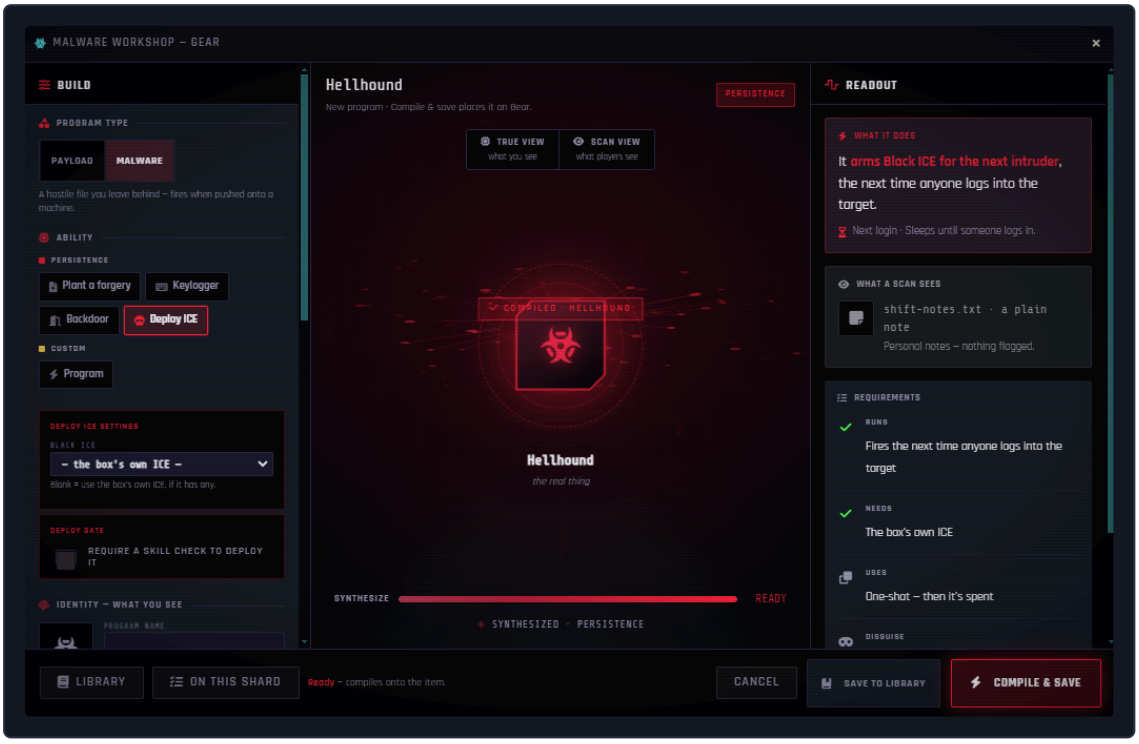
▪ SYSTEM SWEEP — scan a machine for planted programs. It never says what it missed.

FIGHTING BACK

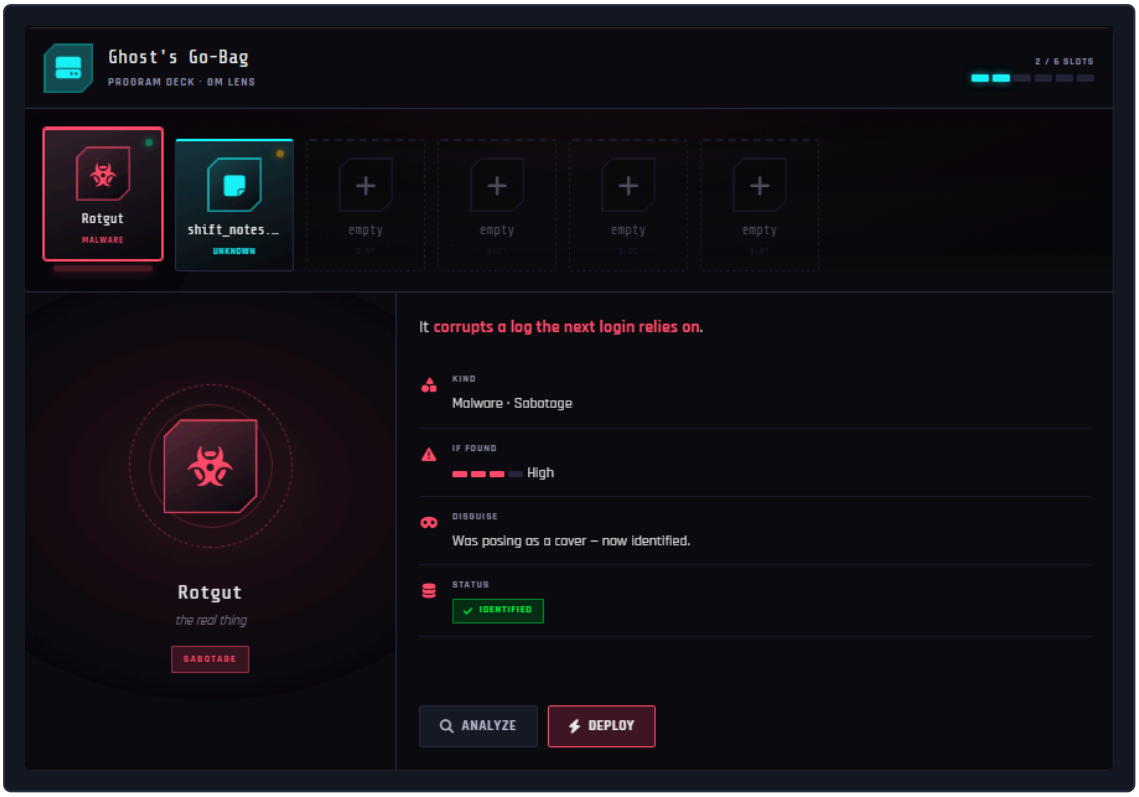
Players have tools too. **ANALYZE** checks whether a file is really what it says it is. It is the magnifier button on a file's header, in a terminal and on a shard alike — but only on *typed* files (a spreadsheet, a photo gallery, a program…); a plain message has nothing to analyze, so it shows no button. **SYSTEM SWEEP** scans a whole terminal for planted programs — it lives in the mailbox's OPS menu next to Upload, reveals what the roll is good enough to find, and never says whether it missed anything.

THE MALWARE WORKSHOP

Admin → Security → **Programs** opens the **Malware Workshop**. Build programs with real effects: keyloggers, secret backdoor accounts, ICE traps, logic bombs, file wipers. You can disguise them as harmless files. Give them to players as Items; they carry and use them through the **Program Deck**.



- The Malware Workshop — the cover story on top, what the program really does underneath.



▪ The Program Deck — how players carry and inspect the programs you hand them.

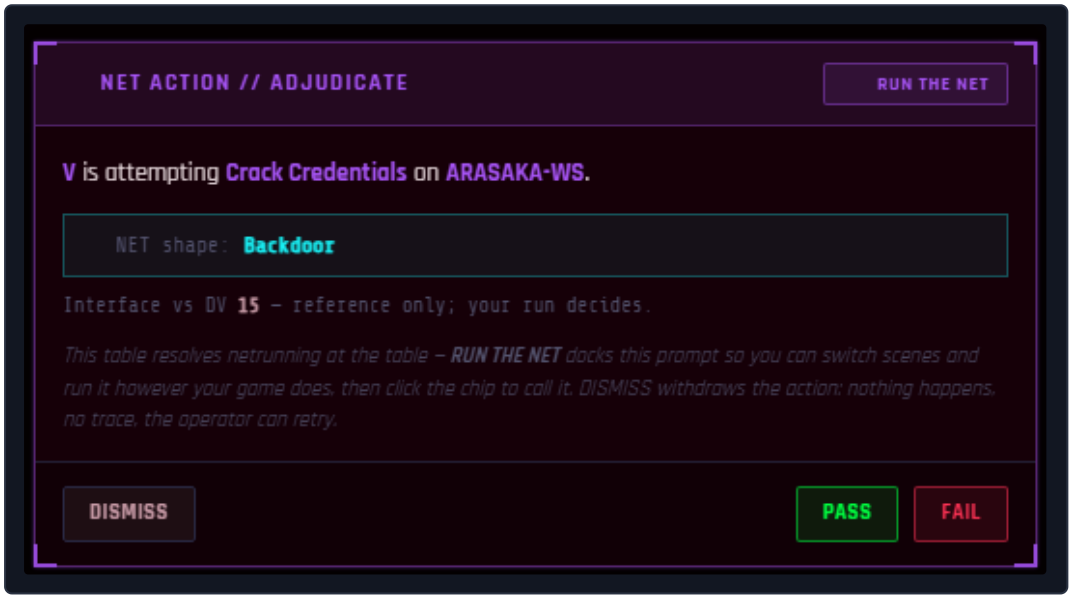
▸ WHO CAN HACK AT ALL

Admin → Security → **Operator Access** lets you limit who can use terminals: by role, by skill level, by gear they need to own, or by naming specific characters.

HOW HACK ROLLS GET RESOLVED

There's a setting called **Netrunning Resolution** with three modes. Pick what fits your table:

1. **Auto** — the module rolls and resolves everything. Fast. This is the default.
2. **Flagged** — same as auto, but you get a card telling you what happened so you can work it into the story.
3. **GM decides** — no auto-roll. The player's screen waits while you get a prompt. Run the netrun at the table however you like, then click the result. Both screens can minimize while you play it out.



"GM decides" mode: the prompt you get when a player attempts a hack — run the NET at the table, then call it.

// PART 08 · EVERYONE

Three rules to remember

These three things cause almost every "it's broken" report. Tell your players up front:

1 A GM HAS TO BE ONLINE FOR PLAYER ACTIONS TO COUNT

When a player claims money, decrypts a file, or uploads something, the change goes through the GM's computer. If no GM is connected, nothing happens. That's on purpose.

2 CHECK THE OPERATOR CHIP

It picks which character rolls and gets paid. Wrong chip, wrong wallet.

3 "THE BUTTON DOES NOTHING" IS USUALLY A SETTING

Exfil rules, operator access, network range, resolution mode — check the setting before assuming it's a bug. Turning on **Debug Mode** makes the module explain every decision in the console.

ALSO GOOD TO KNOW Self-destructing messages never destroy when a GM reads them (so you can check inboxes safely), and GMs skip most login checks — so if you want to see what players see, log in from a player account.

// PART 09 · GM

Settings that matter

All in Module Settings. The important ones:

SETTING	WHAT IT DOES
Time Provider	which clock the module uses
Require Contact Verification	players can only message addresses they know
Smart Conversation Grouping	groups same-subject mail into threads
Anonymous Send	the masked-sender feature
Spam: Unknown Sender	chance for mail from strangers to land in Spam
Netrunning Resolution	auto / flagged / GM decides
Planted Program Firing	fire on their own, or ask you first
Exfil Folder Name	what the players' stolen-files folder is called
Notify GM of NPC Mail	popup when players message NPCs
Auto-register NPC Senders	sending from an NPC actor adds it to your contact directory
Terminal Pins Auto-Show	map pins visible without extra clicks
Debug Mode	the module explains its decisions in the console

// PART 10 · GM

How to run your first sessions

A pacing that works:

1. **Before session 1:** set up two networks and a dead zone, add three contacts, and send each player one message from someone their character knows. It'll be waiting when they first open their phone.
2. **Session 1:** players make their addresses, style their phones, and message each other and an NPC. You answer in character. That's enough. Let it breathe.
3. **Session 2:** a job offer arrives by mail — maybe anonymously. Payment attached as eddies. The job involves a data shard with three entries: a plain message, a locked photo, a bank account.
4. **Session 3:** the job leads to a terminal pinned on the map. Two accounts, one hidden. A camera feed, an incriminating spreadsheet, and a download action that needs a roll. Let someone fail and watch the heat show up on your Security tab.
5. **Later:** forged evidence, malware, countdowns, and letting players make their own shards. Add them when the table asks, not before.

NIGHT CITY MESSENGER · for Foundry VTT v12 + Cyberpunk RED Core
github.com/christinophrappuccino/night-city-messenger

Wake up, samurai. You've got mail.